I cast my net not so widely as to imperil the mission, but widely enough to avoid a single point of failure—the *New York Times* problem. One journalist, one publication, even one country of publication wouldn't be enough, because the US government had already demonstrated its willingness to stifle such reporting. Ideally, I'd give each journalist their own set of documents simultaneously, leaving me with none. This would shift the focus of scrutiny to them, and ensure that even if I were arrested the truth would still get out.

As I narrowed down my list of potential partners, I realized I'd been going about this all wrong, or just wastefully. Instead of trying to select the journalists on my own, I should have been letting the system that I was trying to expose select them for me. My best partners, I decided, would be journalists whom the national security state had already targeted.

Laura Poitras I knew as a documentarian, primarily concerned with America's post-9/11 foreign policy. Her film *My Country, My Country* depicted the 2005 Iraqi national elections that were conducted under (and frustrated by) the US occupation. She had also made *The Program*, about the NSA cryptanalyst William Binney—who had raised objections through proper channels about TRAILBLAZER, the predecessor of STELLARWIND, only to be accused of leaking classified information, subjected to repeated harassment, and arrested at gunpoint in his home, though never charged. Laura herself had been frequently harassed by the government because of her work, repeatedly detained and interrogated by border agents whenever she traveled in or out of the country.

Glenn Greenwald I knew as a civil liberties lawyer turned columnist, initially for *Salon*—where he was one of the few who wrote about the unclassified version of the NSA IG's Report back in 2009—and later for the US edition of the *Guardian*. I liked him because he was skeptical and argumentative, the kind of man who'd fight with the devil, and when the devil wasn't around fight with himself. Though Ewen MacAskill, of the British edition of the *Guardian*, and Bart Gellman of the *Washington Post* would later prove stalwart partners (and patient guides to the journalistic wilderness), I found my earliest affinity with Laura and Glenn, perhaps because they weren't merely interested in reporting on the IC but had personal stakes in understanding the institution.

The only hitch was getting in touch.

Unable to reveal my true name, I contacted the journalists under a variety of identities, disposable masks worn for a time and then discarded. The first of these was "Cincinnatus," after the legendary farmer who became a Roman consul and then voluntarily relinquished his power. That was followed by